

THE SOCIAL UNIVERSE (TSU)

Master Platform Roster — Fictional Counterparts

Franchise Mandate: Every real-world platform gets a fictional 1:1 analog — same cultural role, same rise/fall arc, same "powers" — built to be owned, merchandised, and continued past where reality stops. Faithful to the *spirit* of the source, not the *name* of it.

Organized like MCU Phases: founding era -> expansion -> fragmentation -> the current cinematic battlefield.

PHASE 0 — THE PRECURSORS (1997–2001)

The ones nobody remembers using but everyone owes a debt to.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
SixDegrees.com	1997	First "profile + friends list" site	THE LEDGER	A stark, almost bureaucratic site that treated friendship like a legal registry — literally asked users to "notarize" connections. Ahead of its time, dead by 2001. Origin-myth status — everyone quotes its founder's manifesto; nobody used it.
Classmates.com	1995	Reunite old school contacts	ROLL CALL	Yearbook-themed, nostalgia-driven, quietly profitable forever by refusing to evolve. Always in the background, funding things.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
LiveJournal	1999	Confessional blogging + micro-communities	DEAR DIARY	Built by ex-poets, beloved by teenage goths and fandom communities. Becomes the site every other platform's writers secretly still use — hidden, culturally rich, underestimated.
GeoCities	1994	DIY personal hompages, "neighborhoods"	HOMESTEAD	Users build literal digital houses in themed "districts" (you had to pick a neighborhood to live in). Gloriously ugly, deeply personal. The site's shutdown becomes TSU's first mass-erasure event ("The First Erasure") — an entire generation's homes gone overnight.

PHASE 1 — THE FOUNDING FOUR (2002–2004)

Each of the founding four gets an origin film.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Friendster	2002	First mainstream social network; collapsed under its own success	THE FIRST CIRCLE	Invented "the friend graph" as a status symbol. Founder is a visionary who refuses to add features fast enough — killed by his own perfectionism, not by a villain. A tragic-hero origin: brilliant, cautious, ultimately consumed by what he built.
MySpace	2003	Customizable profiles, music/band culture, "Top 8" social hierarchy	TOP8	Explicitly named after its own most infamous feature — ranking your best friends publicly was social warfare. Music-scene launchpad, glitter-HTML chaos, an unelected mayor-of-the-internet figure everyone's first friend. Brash, beloved, a little embarrassing, genuinely royal in its prime.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
LinkedIn	2003	Professional networking	THE BOARDROOM	Everyone's there, nobody admits to checking it, deeply powerful in ways users don't respect until they need a job. Unglamorous, always working in the background, secretly runs everything. No core-seven founder (locked) — already a mature "old guard" institution before Phase 1's story begins; cameo-only in <code>scripts/THE_ROSTER.md</code> scene 13.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
TheFacebook	2004	Harvard-exclusive, exploded into global dominance, founder disputes	THE ROSTER	Started as an industry-verification flex — verified working entertainment professionals only, a "who's actually real" layer before anyone called it that. Founder-dispute subplot intact (co-founder frozen out via cap-table dilution, a legal fight over origins) — but fictionalized enough to own outright. Arrogant, magnetic, built an empire and burned bridges doing it. Founders (locked): Marc-Anthony Bullock, with Amond Baker diluted out as co-founder. TSU Film 1 ("Iron Man" release slot) — see scripts/THE_ROSTER.md.

Phase 1 finale event: *THE ROSTER* absorbs and outlasts *TOP8*, mirroring MySpace's real collapse — the first time these platforms actually go to war over the same users.

PHASE 2 — THE MEDIA WARS (2005–2010)

Format specialists — weirder powers, more fun.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
YouTube	2005	Video hosting, "Broadcast Yourself"	THE PROJECTOR	Democratized video the way printing presses democratized text. Its origin story literally starts as a failed dating site pivot — perfect comic-tragic energy: didn't mean to end up here, ends up defining the era anyway. Founder (locked): Tyrese Avery. TSU Film 4 ("Thor" release slot) — see scripts/THE_PROJECTOR.md.
Reddit	2005	Anonymous forums, upvote democracy, niche communities	THE HIVE	A shapeshifting city of a thousand tiny nations (subreddits), governed by karma instead of currency. Volatile, occasionally heroic, occasionally a mob — chaotic, smarter than it looks, capable of real loyalty.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Twitter	2006	Real-time, 140-character public square	THE WIRE	Started as a "what are you doing" status tool, mutated into the planet's nervous system for breaking news and public meltdowns. Fast, addictive, structurally incapable of nuance — everything happens through it before anyone can process it. Founder (locked): Amond Baker, solo, post-ROSTER. TSU Film 2 ("Incredible Hulk" release slot) — a power built from his own wound that grows angrier and less controllable than he intended. Script: scripts/THE_WIRE.md.
Tumblr	2007	Aesthetic microblogging, fandom/art hub, reblog culture	THE GALLERY	A wall that never runs out of wall. Fandom, art, activism, and chaos coexist in the same infinite scroll — a little mystical, attracts a specific kind of devoted believer, operates by different rules than everyone else.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Instagram	2010	Photo-first, filtered, aspirational	THE FRAME	Turns every user into a magazine editor of their own life. Origin as a bare-bones check-in app that got reduced to just photos + filters — addition by subtraction. Became the platonic ideal by stripping everything down to its purest form. Founder (locked): Arianna Cummings. TSU Film 5 ("Captain America: The First Avenger" release slot) — see scripts/THE_FRAME.md .

Phase 2 finale event: *THE FRAME* gets quietly acquired by *THE ROSTER* — the empire absorbing its most dangerous young rival instead of fighting it.

PHASE 3 — THE MOBILE INFINITY SAGA (2010–2017)

The stakes go global.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Pinterest	2010	Visual mood-boarding, aspirational planning	THE ATLAS	A map of things you want your life to become. Quiet, huge, oddly powerful in commerce (it's where people plan weddings, renovations, everything) — underestimated because it's coded "unserious." Soft-spoken, immensely powerful, nobody sees it coming.
WhatsApp	2009	Private, encrypted, global messaging	THE WHISPER NETWORK	No profiles, no feed, no performance — just a billion private conversations happening at once, invisible to the public platforms warring above it. Works in the shadows, more essential to the outcome than anyone in the spotlight realizes.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Snapchat	2011	Disappearing content, intimacy through impermanence	THE EMBER	Everything it shows burns up on purpose. Built an entire language (streaks, stories) around things <i>not</i> lasting — the anti-Facebook. A genuinely new kind of being, born from a totally different philosophy than everything that came before it. Founder (locked): Tyler Chapman — the franchise's one deliberately late founding, launched in-story five years after this table's real-world anchor year on purpose (see scripts/THE_EMBER.md's pitch section). TSU Film 12 ("Ant-Man" release slot, closing Release Phase 2) — see scripts/THE_EMBER.md.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Vine	2013	6-second looping video, killed too soon	THE FLICKER	Brilliant, beloved, gone in under two years — a supernova. Its death becomes a mass-mourning event for TSU ("The Flicker Goes Dark"): an entire generation of comedians orphaned overnight, several founding a diaspora that reshapes <i>THE PROJECTOR</i> years later — shocking, formative, permanently mourned by the fandom.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Discord	2015	Voice/text communities, gaming-rooted, server culture	THE OUTPOST	Started as a tool for one specific tribe (gamers) and quietly became the internet's town hall of private nations — a thousand walled gardens nobody outside them can see into. Hidden in plain sight, more technologically advanced than anyone gives it credit for, eventually forced onto the world stage. Founders (locked): Kwame "K-Dot" Ashford-Petrov, Benji Oyelaran-Cox, Sister Rosalind Okonjo, and Felicity Drummond-Asante — the franchise's first founding team with no core-seven member on it. TSU Film 10 ("Guardians of the Galaxy" release slot) — see scripts/THE_OUTPOST.md.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
Google+	2011	One unified identity/profile layer across an entire tech giant's products; dead within 4 years	THE EVERYTHING	One login, one profile, one feed built to absorb every other platform's function at once — hubris given a product name. Built by Cassius Wren as a direct hostile bid against THE ROSTER, THE WIRE, THE PROJECTOR, and THE FRAME simultaneously; collapses within a year of launch from a single catastrophic security failure at maximum possible scale, exactly the way the real thing died from nobody actually wanting one app to do everything. Founder (locked): Cassius Wren. TSU Film 6 ("The Avengers" release slot, Phase 1 finale) — the villain, not a hero. See scripts/THE_ASSEMBLY.md.

PHASE 4 — THE ALGORITHM AGE (2018–PRESENT)

The multiverse saga. Everything fragments, everything competes for the same eyeballs, nobody trusts the timeline anymore.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
TikTok	2016/18	Algorithm-first short video, foreign-owned, geopolitical lightning rod	THE ORACLE	Doesn't ask what you want to see — <i>tells</i> you, with unsettling accuracy. Foreign-born, endlessly scrutinized by governments, impossible to look away from. Not evil, just inevitable — reshapes the entire landscape by sheer gravitational force. The Phase 4 antagonist.
BeReal	2020	Anti-algorithm, unfiltered, simultaneous posting	THE MIRROR	A rebellion platform built entirely as a rejection of THE FRAME and THE ORACLE — forces authenticity by removing the ability to perform. A resistance cell, not an empire — young, idealistic, built specifically to fight what came before it.
Threads	2023	THE ROSTER's answer to THE WIRE's chaos	THE ECHO	Launched overnight by the empire (THE ROSTER) specifically to cannibalize a wounded rival (THE WIRE) — a direct, almost cynical act of corporate warfare. Created by the establishment specifically to destroy a threat, arguably becomes just as dangerous.

Real Platform	Year	Real Role	Fictional Counterpart	Concept
X (formerly THE WIRE)	2023	Ownership change, rebrand, chaos era	THE WIRE, REBORN AS: SIGNAL-0	The old public square, bought out and rebuilt by an outsider with his own agenda — same infrastructure, radically different philosophy, half its former population fled to rival platforms overnight. Familiar shape, fundamentally changed rules.

THE VILLAINS BENCH

(Non-platform entities — services, trends, and forces that antagonize across every Phase)

Real-World Concept	Fictional Counterpart	Role
The Algorithm (generic)	THE ENGINE	Not a platform — the force <i>inside</i> every platform that decides what you see. Whoever controls it controls everything. Every platform has one; none of them admit how much power it has.
Data breaches / privacy scandals	THE LEAK	A recurring catastrophic event, not a character — a disaster that hits a different platform every Phase, always with the same beat: trust breaks, users flee, someone testifies before Congress.
Influencer culture / MLM-adjacent grift	THE SWARM	A parasitic subculture that infects every platform in turn, reskinning itself each time (bloggers -> YouTubers -> Instagram influencers -> TikTokers). A recurring trickster antagonist — never fully defeated, just rebranded.

Real-World Concept	Fictional Counterpart	Role
Bots / fake engagement	THE COPIES	An army, not a villain. Swells right before a platform's downfall, always dismissed as harmless until it isn't.

OPEN SLOTS TO DISCUSS

- **~~Google+ (2011)~~** — resolved: see THE EVERYTHING, Phase 3 table above.
- **Clubhouse (2020)** — audio-only, invite-only, burned bright and faded fast. A one-and-done.
- **Yik Yak, Vine's other siblings, Periscope, Tumblr's NSFW-ban fallout, Mastodon/the decentralization movement** — potential Phase 5 "multiverse" candidates.

Doc status: Living document — add rows as we lock in more Phases.